

Faster Web Development Using the Jade Template Language

You can build Web pages faster with the Jade template language. Jade is an elegant and efficient way to do HTML coding. Old HTML files can be easily converted to Jade.



Jade template language is a major milestone in Web development. It helps developers think of modular, reusable sections of Web pages or apps. So it means less time spent and fewer key strokes. It may take a day or two to get comfortable with this new style, but once you are comfortable, you will never go back to traditional HTML coding.

Tim Berners-Lee, the man who invented the Web, never thought that Web pages would be hand coded using the machine friendly HTML (markup language). With the introduction of Wiki and blog editors, people can publish content on the web without learning HTML. But this does not solve the challenges that Web and app developers face with HTML. We still need to hand code each page.

Mastering HTML involves a steep learning curve. HTML is more browser-friendly than human-friendly, with its tags, attributes, angular brackets and DOM structure. These severely impact readability and maintainability. In addition, HTML has its own idiosyncrasies. Various

types of elements are treated differently—in some cases, the closing tag is optional; while for others, there is no closing tag. With new revisions to HTML, what was mandatory earlier has become optional subsequently (refer to 'The HTML Syntax' in the *References* section). Though templating languages like Jade do not eliminate all the difficulties in learning and using HTML, they are a major step towards faster Web development.

Inline page templating languages like PHP and JSP have been around for a while. They too achieve the same result as the new templating languages. But the latter do their job elegantly with a strong philosophy behind them. Jade has been inspired by another template language called HAML.

The Jade templating engine is not only for HTML page development, but also for other markup languages like XML.

This article contains many practical tips and examples not available in online documentation.